To summarize, the gene's eye view of life, the central theme of this book, illuminates not just the evolution of altruism and selfishness, as expounded in previous editions. It also illuminates the deep past, in ways of which I had no inkling when I first wrote *The Selfish Gene* and which are expounded more fully in relevant passages (largely written by Yan, my co-author) of the second edition (2016) of *The Ancestor's Tale.* So powerful is the gene's eye view, the genome of a single individual is sufficient to make quantitatively detailed inferences about historical demography. What else might it be capable of? As foreshadowed by the Nigerian comparison, future analyses of individuals from different parts of the world could give a geographic dimension to these demographic signals from the past.

Might the gene's eye view penetrate the remote past in yet other ways? Several of my books have developed an idea which I called 'The Genetic Book of the Dead'. The gene pool of a species is a mutually supportive cartel of genes that have survived in particular environments of the past, both distant and recent. This makes it a kind of negative imprint of those environments. A sufficiently knowledgeable geneticist should be able to read out, from the genome of an animal, the environments in which its ancestors survived. In principle, the DNA in a mole *Talpa europaea* should be eloquent of an underground world, a world of damp, subterranean darkness, smelling of worms, leaf decay, and beetle larvae. The DNA of a dromedary, *Camelus dromedarius,* if we but knew how to read it, would spell out a coded description of ancient ancestral deserts, dust storms, dunes, and thirst. The DNA of *Tursiops truncatus,* the common bottlenose dolphin, spells, in a language that we may one day decipher, 'open sea, pursue fish fast, avoid killer whales'. But the same dolphin DNA also contains paragraphs about earlier worlds in which the genes also survived: on land when the ancestors escaped the attentions of tyrannosaurs and allosaurs long enough to breed. Then, before that, parts of the DNA surely spell out descriptions of even older feats of survival, back in the sea, when the ancestors were fish, pursued by sharks and even eurypterids (giant sea scorpions). Active research on 'The Genetic Book of the Dead' lies in the future. Will it colour the epilogue of the fiftieth anniversary edition of *The Selfish Gene?*